MEAL function and competencies

Paper MEC-09, policy P4 of 7, for decision

Friday 20 November 2026, Session 3, 10:45–11:45 | Block B. Capability and financing | For decision

Draft of 4 November 2026 for TWG review. Parameters such as deadlines, response times and thresholds not set by the Framework are proposals, shown as such in the decision options.

The policy in brief

Every Country Office designates a MEAL focal point with terms of reference, protected time and a reporting line to the WR; MEAL competencies are verified, and focal points are certified through the Performance Intelligence Academy by March 2028.

Why this policy

Tools do not use themselves. The Framework's test of a mature system is that it keeps working when staff change, and that depends on people who own the function, have the time to do it and can interpret evidence, not only compile it.

Today MEAL is often a fractional add-on to a programme role, and competence is assumed from job titles. This policy sets the minimum the Framework requires: an identified focal point, a clear role, verified skills and continuity.

What the evidence shows

- Focal point arrangements differ from office to office in title, time and reporting line (TWG review, 2026).
- SAM1 2026 points to gaps in interpretation and verification rather than data collection: **1 of 1,336** assessments cites an evidence source, and one rated figure in five is estimated or unavailable.
- Staffing is under pressure: in July 2026, **46 of 53** budget centres had less than 75% of their staff costs funded, which leaves MEAL roles exposed.

Scope

The 47 Country Offices, the Regional Office clusters and the MSC Unit.

The policy

1. **A named focal point.** By 31 January 2027, each WR designates a MEAL focal point by name, with terms of reference based on the MSC template. The terms set out the responsibilities of Annex C (Domains 1 and 11), the protected time and the reporting line to the WR on MEAL matters.
2. **Protected time.** The share of working time protected for MEAL is written into the terms of reference and the focal point's performance objectives. The MEC sets the minimum (see options).
3. **Proportionate coverage.** The office's MEAL structure is proportionate to its portfolio (Annex A, 11.1). The development plan sets it out, including the MEAL responsibilities of programme leads.
4. **Verified competencies.** MEAL competencies are defined in the competency framework of the Performance Intelligence Academy (Annex M) and verified, not assumed from job titles (Annex A, 11.2). Until Annex M is issued, the competency framework of the MEAL Competency Development Programme applies. Recruitment to MEAL roles uses them.
5. **Certification by March 2028.** Focal points complete the core track of the Performance Intelligence Academy, the MEAL Competency Development Programme, and are certified by 31 March 2028. WRs and programme leads take part in the leadership orientation on the Framework (Annex F) in 2027.
6. **Continuity.** Before a focal point leaves, a handover note covers the development plan, the decision log and the data sources. The WR designates an interim focal point within 30 days.
7. **A regional network.** Focal points belong to the Regional MEAL Practitioners Network, facilitated by MSC, which also provides the pool of Learning Lab facilitators.

8. **Regional Office focal points.** Each Regional Office cluster names a MEAL focal point who supports Country Offices in its area and handles their MEAL support requests (see P6).

Who does what

WHO Representative	Designates the focal point, protects the time and keeps the role filled.
MEAL focal point	Carries the responsibilities in the terms of reference; completes certification.
Human resources	Reflects MEAL roles and competencies in post descriptions, recruitment and performance objectives.
MSC Unit	Issues the terms of reference template; runs the Academy, certification and the network.
Regional Office clusters	Name a cluster MEAL focal point; release staff for the facilitator pool.

Timeline

When	Milestone
31 Jan 2027	Focal points designated with terms of reference in all 47 offices; cluster focal points named
From Q2 2027	Academy core track in cohorts aligned with the Learning Lab waves
31 Dec 2027	Competencies of all focal points verified
31 Mar 2028	All focal points certified

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Country Offices with a designated focal point and terms of reference	Not yet measured	47 by 31 January 2027
Focal points certified	Not yet measured	100% by 31 March 2028
Focal point vacancies covered within 30 days	Not yet measured	100%

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**As proposed, with at least 50% of the focal point's time protected for MEAL**	A real role in every office; programme work shifts to others in small offices.
B	Designation and terms of reference only; time and certification left to each WR	Least disruption, but MEAL stays an add-on in most offices.
C	A dedicated MEAL officer post in offices above a budget threshold set by the DPM, option A elsewhere	Strongest capacity; requires posts in the 2028–2029 workforce plans, funded within P3.

Resources

Academy delivery and certification by MSC; staff time. Posts under option C are funded within the 3% of P3.

> **The MEC is asked to**
>
> Adopt the MEAL function and competency requirements with at least 50% protected time (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts XI and XII; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 1.2 and 11.1 to 11.4; Annex C, Domains 1 and 11; Annex M (not in this package). Domains: D11 Human capacity; D1 Governance (Sub-dimension 1.2).